army's worst fears were vindicated: the British had indeed lost their leader and Lady Macnaghten had lost her husband.

Among the Afghans, there was jubilation at the astonishing thoroughness of the reversals suffered by the arrogant Firangi invaders, but there was also some chivalrous sympathy for Lady Macnaghten, at least among the poets. In the *Akbarnama,* Maulana Hamid Kashmiri places in her mouth a pained lament that she utters when she is told that her husband will not be returning:

> . . . The wife of *Laat-Hay Jangi*, Lord Hay of War, tore at her collar
> Her grief raged, and out poured her song of bereavement?. . .
>
> She cried: 'O Prince in the Land of Firang!
> You were honoured in *Rum* [Rome/Europe] and famed in Ethiopia!
>
> But in this land you were doomed
> Here your death was certain
>
> Come back! With you, I am happy in poverty
> Beggary would be better than such lordship . . .
>
> . . . Today, street urchins and alley rats
> Play with your rolling head as though it were a ball?. . .
>
> . . . Come back, O proud conqueror!
> You exalted the very crown and throne that were yours
>
> But in Kabul today, upon the dust of the road
> Lies your body without a head, and your head without a crown'[3]

Yet any sympathy expressed by the Maulana was tempered by a certainty that the extraordinary speed of the fall of the once powerful British was due above all to divine displeasure: the lying, deceitful Kafirs had got their just deserts. The final proofs of this, as far as Maulana Kashmiri was concerned, were the unprecedented blizzards which then fell on Kabul to further discomfit the accursed disbelievers:

> Despite suffering such grief and sorrow, such pain and misery
> Heaven did not desist from tormenting them yet again
>
> It girded its loins, bent upon desolation
> Gripping Kabul in the coldest of winters